

Research Proposal - Girls' Youth Sports Participation Following More Channels of Professional Representation

Broad Idea

Broadly, I would like to see if there was any uptick in youth sports participation from girls following the Women's World Cup held in the USA in 1991, when the USWNT won the tournament. Also in the 90's, the WNBA held its inaugural season. I am curious if these two sources of professional athletics spurred girls to participate more in sports, seeing a pathway from participation.

Prior Work

Confounding with this idea is the introduction of Title IX in 1972. This is a scarcely studied phenomenon. I was only able to find one working paper which examined the effect of Title IX on participation. I want to follow much of what was done in that paper, if the advent of professional athleticism served as a motivator for participation, and thus would lead more girls to collegiate athletics.

Data

There is actually a good amount of data on youth athletics. NFHS has data on high school participation, NLSY tracks participation, and there are other datasets which track the younger years, though I am more dubious of these without closer inspection.

Methodological Idea

Event study + IV (though I am still fleshing out the instrument here, ideas welcome). The event would be a window from 1991-1997 and then after 1997 all would be "treated" by exposure to these pro pathways. In the paper mentioned above, they use participation of boys in athletics pre title IX. I am still ruminating on a good way to go about this.

Overall

I think this is an interesting idea given that I could go in multiple directions. First, human capital development via college attendance. This is the easiest, since college scholarships would be the most natural continuation of participating in youth sports. Next, labor outcomes. Because they have a path to college, they can now, ostensibly, be subject to better labor market outcomes. Finally, health. There are multiple studies in medical literature examining the relationship between youth sports and LTH outcomes. This would be an interesting pathway as it was not touched on much in the working paper mentioned previously.